two communist parties and several others. ‘Jan Sangh’s Ram Prakash Gupta, Baldev Prakash, V.K. Saklecha became deputy chief ministers in Uttar Pradesh, Punjab and Madhya Pradesh respectively. Vijay Kumar Malhotra became chief executive councilor in Delhi’s Metropolitan Council, and L.K. Advani, the Chairman (Speaker); Hans Raj Gupta was elected Mayor of Delhi Municipal Corporation; Vijay Kumar Mitra, Ram Deo Mahto and Rudra Pratap Saran became ministers in Bihar.’[106]

This began a new phase of expansion in the Jan Sangh, culminating in the party’s merger with the Janata Party. The BJP headquarters in Delhi still sells a comic book on Nanaji Deshmukh, depicting his key role in ending the Jan Sangh’s isolation and beginning an era of alliance-building after a meeting with the socialist leader Ram Manohar Lohia.

By 1967, a contemporary press account observed: ‘Few political parties have risen so spectacularly as the Bharatiya Jana Sangh.’ Between 1962 and 1967, its membership more than doubled from 6,00,000 to 13,00,000, and it emerged as the ‘major opposition party in north India’. The 1962 war and rehabilitation work done by RSS workers marked an important watershed. When the Indian Institute of Public Opinion predicted that the Jan Sangh could well ‘become India’s largest opposition party in the next two or three years’, *Organiser* splashed it across the front page. For good measure, it took a dig at the party’s English-language critics: ‘Those who always used to scoff are today in a mood to praise, if not to pray.’[107] The Jan Sangh’s political fortunes were clearly on the upswing. As *Weekend Review* noted, it ‘is the only party (of the right) which does not owe its origin to the Congress dissidence movement’. More generally, ‘the Jana Sangh appears to provide an ideal inlet for those pent-up nationalist forces in India which view with alarm the erosion of traditional values in the name of progress’.[108]

Figure 9.6: Nanaji Deshmukh Comic Depicting Alliance-formation with Socialist Leader Ram Manohar Lohia